

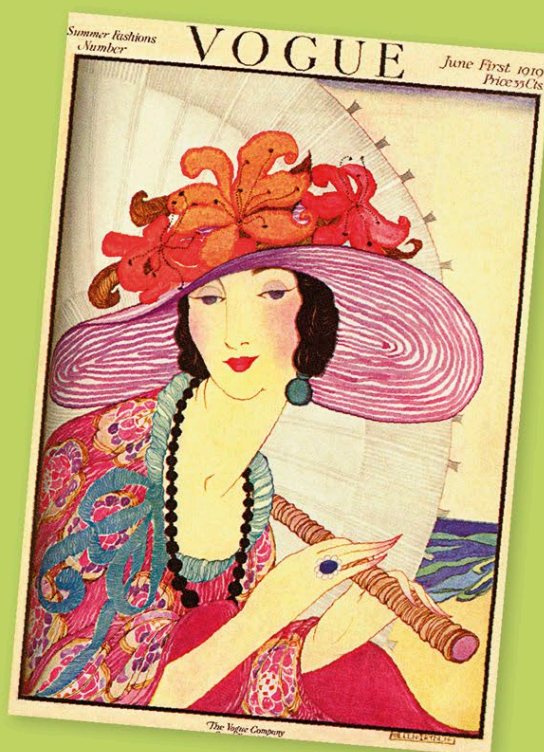
own clothes. Ready-made clothes became available toward the end of the 19th-century, and became more prevalent with the advent of mail order catalogs. By the 20th century, most women's clothing was bought ready-made as a result of mass textile production and the creation of department stores.

Fashion statements

In the early 20th century, the campaign for women's rights, particularly suffrage, influenced fashion. To avoid being labelled masculine, suffragettes presented a consciously elegant image, aided by their adoption, in 1908, of three colors—white for purity, green for hope, and purple for dignity (in the US, gold replaced green).

As the demand for women's rights grew louder, fashion reacted against traditional femininity. From the knee-revealing flapper dress and Coco Chanel's trousers for women in the 1920s to Mary Quant's thigh-baring miniskirts in the 1960s, fashion became a form of rebellion for some. From the late 1970s, women dressed in sober, tailored suits as they strove to establish themselves in traditionally male workplaces. By 1983, women were expressing their views on slogan T-shirts, a trend set by UK designer Katharine Hamnett. A host of female fashion designers, among them Diane von Furstenberg and Donna Karan in the US, and Vivienne Westwood in the UK, began to challenge the dominance of male designers.

Although women are integral to today's fashion industry, it does not always favor them. Women in developing nations making cheap, mass-produced clothes (see pp. 296–297) are among the most exploited by the industry. Critics also point to the fashion industry's obsession with thinness, although since the late 20th century some “plus size” models have begun to appear on catwalks and in campaigns.



▲ In vogue

This vintage *Vogue* cover is from 1919. Founded in 1892, the US magazine was originally targeted at New York's upper class but filtered through to the aspirational middle class.

FRENCH COUTURIER COCO CHANEL IN PARIS, 1936



PROFILES

KEY PLAYERS

Rose Bertin (1747–1813) dressed the most fashionable women in 18th-century Europe. Apprenticed to a Parisian milliner, she built up a following among the capital's aristocratic women, and opened a dress store in 1770. Two years later she became Marie-Antoinette's personal dressmaker. Bertin made her a style icon and popularized the *pouf* hairstyle—a precursor of the modern beehive.

Gabrielle “Coco” Chanel (1883–1971) learned to sew at the French orphanage where she was raised. Three years after becoming a licensed milliner, she opened a boutique in the resort of Deauville in 1910, and began to sell deluxe casual wear adapted from men's clothing. She moved her business to Paris, expanded to sell couture, perfume, and ready-to-wear, and became one of the most influential designers of the early 20th century.

Ann Lowe (1898–1981) was one of the first African American designers to have a successful career in high fashion. She worked in Tampa, Florida, creating dresses for elite women before moving to New York in 1928. There, she became known for designing couture wedding gowns—one of the most famous being that of Jacqueline Bouvier Kennedy, wife of President John F. Kennedy.

Lisa Fonssagrives (1911–1992) was a Swedish model, photographer, designer, and sculptor. She was paid far more than other models, leading some to call her the world's first “supermodel.” Fonssagrives—who once described herself as a “good clothes hanger”—had an unusually long modeling career, lasting from the 1930s until the 1950s.

Wilhelmina Cooper (1939–1980) is a Dutch former model who set records by appearing on the cover of *Vogue* 28 times. She was managed by Eileen Ford's pioneering Ford Modeling Agency, but went on to found her own agency, Wilhelmina Models, in 1967. Her own company grew to rival Ford's in success.

Dame Anna Wintour (b. 1949) has been editor-in-chief of *Vogue* magazine since 1988. Known for her signature severe bobbed haircut, Wintour is one of the most powerful tastemakers in the industry. New York's Metropolitan Museum of Art named its Costume Institute after her when it reopened in 2014.